ANTH0045 Digital Anthropology: Research Methods

Course outline 2026/27 — Term 2 — 15 credits

About this course

ANTH0045 is a methods course taught through practice. Rather than surveying digital anthropology as a literature, we spend the term doing a small piece of fieldwork in an online setting of your choosing and treat the difficulties that arise as the subject matter. Most of what you will learn comes from the gap between the method as described in the reading and the method as it behaves once real people are involved.

The course is convened by Dr H. Lindqvist and is capped at twenty-four students. It is intended for second and third year undergraduates, and for masters students who have not previously done qualitative fieldwork. There is no quantitative component.

How the term is organised

We meet once a week for a two-hour seminar across Term 2, with no meeting in the reading week commencing 15 February 2027. The first four seminars are led by the convenor and cover research design, ethics, consent in online settings, and field note practice. From the fifth seminar onwards the sessions are led by students and organised around whatever the fieldwork has thrown up that week.

Before any fieldwork begins you must have an approved ethics form on file. The form is discussed in the second seminar and must be approved before you make contact with anybody in your field site. This is not a formality, and the department will not accept work based on fieldwork conducted without approval.

What you will produce

The visible output of the course is a research essay, described below. Less visibly, you will produce a great deal of writing that is not the essay: field notes, reading notes, methodological asides, and the record of decisions you made and later regretted. Seminar participation is not assessed directly, though the fieldwork notebook you keep across the term is, and it is handed in alongside the essay. The notebook is marked pass or fail rather than contributing a percentage, and a fail means a fail for the course however good the essay. Two thousand words of notes is typical; students who write considerably less usually find the essay harder, because the essay is largely an argument assembled out of the notebook.

Keep the notebook in whatever form suits you, but keep it in one place and keep it legible to somebody other than yourself. A notebook that cannot be read cannot be marked.

Assessment

The research essay carries sixty per cent of the course mark and runs to 4,000 words, excluding references and any appendices. It should present a focused argument grounded in your own fieldwork rather than a general review of the literature. The essay must be submitted by 12 noon on Friday 5 March 2027 through the Moodle submission point for this course.

The remaining forty per cent is awarded for the seminar presentation in which you take the group through your fieldwork in progress. Presentations run in the second half of term and your slot is

allocated by the convenor in the first seminar, once we know how many students are taking the course and what their field sites are. The schedule is circulated by email and posted on Moodle. It is not fixed in advance of the first meeting, and has in previous years changed during the term as field sites fell through.

A reading list sign-up for the student-led seminars opens in Week 2 and closes once every session has a presenter. Signing up is a scheduling exercise and carries no marks of its own, though the quality of the session you lead informs the presentation mark.

A note on the word limit

The word limit on the essay is a limit and not a target. Essays over the limit are penalised according to the faculty scheme. The notebook has no limit in either direction.

Ethics, consent and data

Online fieldwork makes consent genuinely difficult, and the course spends a full seminar on why. You are responsible for the data you collect, including deleting it when the course ends. Do not store field material in services your participants could plausibly access, and do not quote anybody in the essay in a way that would let a reader find them.

Support

The convenor holds office hours weekly through Term 2; the times are on Moodle. Fieldwork goes wrong for almost everybody at some point, and the earlier you say so the more can be done about it. If your field site collapses entirely, come and see the convenor rather than trying to rescue it alone.